

Amateurs and professionals

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Growing up, my friends and I felt that the difference between the 12-year-old us and say, Sunil Gavaskar or Prakash Padukone (**in pic**) was that they worked harder, practiced more, and had better equipment. But they were essentially the same as us, the difference being one of degree.

The fantasy was that if you worked just as hard you might become like them. It is a good fantasy for a 12-year-old to nurture.

As we grew older (with wisdom arriving as an optional extra), we saw it wasn't that simple. Professional sportsmen had something that was not accessible to the amateur, although the latter could bowl the one delivery that might dismiss a Gavaskar or place that one shot past a Prakash. It was a difference in kind.

The years between the birth of the fantasy and the dawning of realisation are the most exciting ever. These are the Santa Claus years when you believed, in a sense, that there was a Santa Claus. But increasingly it becomes clear we don't inhabit the same planet as the champions.

Soon, on a Sunday morning, we begin a routine, having signed a pact with fitness. It is elastic, easily renegotiated. The shuttle is unpacked, the racquet examined, and the court becomes a stage for laughter, mild exertion, and anecdotes.

For the professional, there is no romance in waking up early, only routine. Where the amateur measures success in sweat and satisfaction, the professional measures it in millimetres. The weekend badminton player plays to pass time. The professional plays to master it.



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We allow ourselves the luxury of experimentation — an ambitious smash here, an audacious drop there — often with results that are cheerfully disastrous. A point lost is an anecdote gained.

The professional, on the other hand, is a study in tyranny. Every movement has been rehearsed into muscle memory. The jump smash is not a flourish but a calculation, the drop shot not a surprise but certainty disguised. Even joy is rationed, revealed only in brief, controlled bursts — a clenched fist, a fleeting smile.

Many who played alongside Prakash Padukone at the Canara Union in Bengaluru were talented amateurs; some went on to represent India. Yet the difference in class between that lot of players and Prakash was clear from the beginning.

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So the rest of us have a role to play, after all. Not great ourselves, we can be the cause of greatness in others.

There is, however, a fleeting moment when our separate worlds overlap. The amateur strikes the shuttle just right, the sound crisp, the trajectory perfect. For that instant, time pauses, effort disappears, and the game reveals its purest form. It is a professional's shot, born in an amateur's court.

And that is reward enough in our evolved state of reduced ambition.